Deflected Disruption:
Payments and the Taming of Chinese Fintech

Colin Chia · Jingding Wang

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Why and how do state authorities seek to deflect and harness technological disruption? Under what conditions do they shift between welcoming disruptive innovation as a driver of economic modernisation and seeing it as a threat to political and financial stability? This paper examines these questions in the context of how authorities handled the emergence of Fintech attached to digital platform companies within mainland China and their international expansion to Southeast Asia. Fintech has grown rapidly in China, and disrupting the payments system was a key part of its growth. Over 1 billion people in China use digital payment services for everyday transactions, predominantly Alipay and WeChat Pay, and such non-bank payment providers accounted for transactions worth between 337.8 to 563.7 trillion yuan in 2025, or at least 2.4 times China's GDP (PBC, 2026; Statista, 2024). Relegating credit cards and account-to-account (A2A) systems to a secondary role, they have disrupted the domestic payments landscape to an extent that is not seen in other countries (see figure 2). However, since late 2020 authorities have acted strongly to rein in platforms like Alibaba, WeChat, Meituan, and Didi amid their growth in market power and concerns about political disruption. We also examine the relatively limited impact of Chinese Fintech platforms in Southeast Asia, a region that has been a key target for international expansion. Outside China, they have struggled as new entrants in developed and highly competitive markets, and where regulators and incumbents were less likely to have compatible interests in technological disruption of existing regulatory arrangements.

We argue that intermediation and the informational power derived from it is key to making sense of the trajectory of Fintech disruption. As technology evolved, control of financial infrastructure and intermediation shifted between Fintechs and traditional banking, and with it informational power over and through data on economic behaviour. Authorities and banking incumbents, particularly at the local level, were accommodating of disruption to the extent it aligned with goals of payment systems modernisation, economic growth and efficiency. However, they were less tolerant of Fintech disruption when it compromised their intermediary positions and informational power, and acted more strongly to deflect or block it. Disruption is understood as the use of technological innovation to gain advantages over other actors by changing existing systems and infrastructures

(Hodson et al., 2026). A common perception is that disruptive innovation is deployed by private firms pursuing their economic interests, and that incumbents necessarily resist this challenge to the status quo. However, state authorities are not necessarily against disruption, rather they might work to deflect the trajectory of private Fintech innovation towards governance objectives.

This paper focusses on two vectors of disruption identified in this special issue: disruption of financial governance, and disruption of international monetary orders. The first vector is visible through the interaction between China's major digital services firms, who deployed Fintech innovations that disrupted financial systems as a spillover from innovations in payments systems that allowed them to gain intermediary positions and informational power. The notion of deflected disruption in Fintech helps to understand the interrelated dynamics of this process and its outcomes in mainland China. State authorities did not simply try to stop Fintech disruption, but saw some aspects of it positively and sought to deflect disruption towards goals like economic development or banking and financial system modernisation. However, since late 2020 authorities have acted strongly to rein in platforms like Alibaba, WeChat, Meituan, and Didi amid their growth in market power and concerns about political disruption. Hence, 'deflection' suggests that authorities shifted the trajectory of disruption, without fully controlling its direction or stopping it.

The second vector of disruption to international monetary orders can be examined in terms of the regional and global currency hierarchy (Cohen, 2019). These same Fintech companies have often been portrayed as instruments of Chinese economic statecraft that could help internationalise the renminbi and increase Beijing's monetary power internationally (Liu, 2023; Rolf and Schindler, 2025). In this view, trade finance and payments systems might facilitate greater use of China's currency outside its territory, bringing with it advantages similar to US dollar hegemony. We examine their impact on domestic and cross-border payments in the neighbouring and rapidly growing region of Southeast Asia. We find that the international expansion and disruptive potential of Chinese Fintechs was limited by intense commercial competition and concerns about Beijing's political influence, even in a region with extensive economic relations with China. Chinese digital services platforms' inability to effectively compete against homegrown digital services platforms limited the informational power and reintermediation they achieved at home. Their failure to gain ground in Southeast Asia further highlights how disruption can spill from one country to another, but its effects can nevertheless be contained or harnessed by authorities wary of their potential as a vector for political disruption. Regulators in Southeast Asia have enforced strong regulations that limit the role foreign entities can play in this crucial economic infrastructure. This international aspect of payments disruption further illustrates both the disruptive potential of Fintech, and how states can deflect and harness it even when firms enjoy advantages of scale and the implicit political backing of a major power.

We proceed in three parts. First, we set out a framework for analysing how payments systems can be a vector for disruption of financial governance, political authority, and international mon-

etary orders. Specifically, we focus on intermediation as a source of informational power, which technological change in payments disrupts by putting into play the intermediary positions of incumbent banks and state authorities. Second, we apply this to the case of China, arguing that its payments system was disrupted to an unusually large extent for two interrelated reasons: Fintech burst onto the scene in the context of rapid growth of digital services, and it was supported by government actors who saw Fintech firms as driving technological and economic development. This allowed Alibaba (known as Ant Group from October 2014) and Tencent to become the leading payment providers in China. Third, we examine the international dimensions of Chinese Fintech's expansion in Southeast Asia. The disruptive potential of Chinese Fintechs has been deflected in Southeast Asia by intense homegrown competition and government efforts to build, maintain, and carefully regulate autonomous digital payments and financial infrastructures. Our findings suggest that concerns about intermediation and informational power are key issues which guide how political authorities govern Fintech disruption, seeking to harness and deflect it towards their goals. This international dimension highlights different means that state authorities in mainland China and Southeast Asia used towards similar ends of maintaining governance capacity and political agency.

In methodological terms, we construct an analytic narrative based on a wide range of government, industry, and media sources. This includes central bank policy documents, company annual reports, and reporting and research from within the financial industry and media. This allows us to put together a systematic analysis of China's Fintech ecosystem, its origins, development, and the evolution of state policy towards it, as well as how authorities in Southeast Asia handled their outward expansion. This paper contributes to research on the politics of payments and Fintech by assessing and analysing Fintech's disruptive potential and how it was channelled or deflected by various political and economic actors, by highlighting intermediation and informational power as key stakes of this contestation. This descriptive analysis (Gerring, 2017) aims to enable further research on the international and comparative political economy of payments systems.

1 Intermediation and the dynamics of payments disruption

Money is fundamentally a social and political claim on economic production (Eich, 2022; Helleiner, 2003; Kapadia, 2024). In a modern economy, payments systems enable money's circulation and exchange into goods and services. Accordingly, payments technologies have implications for a basic infrastructure that shapes economic life and enables the transfer of value between members of society (Bernards and Campbell-Verduyn, 2019; Clarke, 2019). Within banking and financial infrastructures, actors who hold intermediary positions play crucial roles enabling large-scale economic interaction (Maurer, 2012). This also allows them to 'deploy digital infrastructures to extract value from intermediation', extracting rent even as they offer improved overall efficiency for users (Langley and Leyshon, 2021: 376). This privileged access to data makes intermediation a source

of informational power which Fintech firms often challenge existing intermediaries like banks and regulators to gain, a crucial dynamic seen with digital platforms more generally (Srnicek, 2017; Steinberg, 2019).

We build on these insights by analysing the dynamic processes through which digital services firms in China used Fintech innovations to disrupt payments and banking by supplanting existing intermediaries and accumulating informational power. We highlight that disruptive technological change does not only work for those who deploy it. Thus, although digital platforms were the most prominent in driving technological change, firms like Ant Group and Tencent were not the only players steering the trajectory of disruption within China. Authorities worked to deflect payment technologies away from disrupting financial regulation and towards improving the system's efficiency and competitiveness. At times, authorities' interest in payments and financial system modernisation aligned with the business interests of the digital platforms, while at others regulators acted to curtail disruption that was perceived as creating economic and political risks. Disruption in payments infrastructures can thus be understood as part of a struggle in which payment technologies help actors to gain or maintain positions as financial intermediaries.

Much of the disruptive power of Fintech lies not only in payment processing but also in the informational power derived from intermediation. As Giddens (1990: 23–27) observed, money functions as a distanciation device helping to overcome the informational constraints of time and space in market exchange. Especially when linked to digital services and marketplace platforms, payments infrastructure becomes the primary device to extract behavioural data about users. Each payment produces information that allows financial institutions to learn about customer behaviour, manage risk, and develop new products. The smoother and more integrated the information flow, with minimal barriers or redirections, the greater the efficiency and strategic value. However, as the ownership and management of the infrastructure changes, informational power is redistributed towards those who hold or gain central positions as intermediaries (Langley and Leyshon, 2021). The rise of digital payments and Fintech services has intensified this trend by further dematerialising money and embedding economic activity into data-driven systems. Disruption is thus not only about competition between firms and participants in a market, but how technological change affects the structures of monetary and financial power by allowing actors to reshape their roles and relationships within infrastructures.

The example of China stands out because studies of the impact of mobile and digital payments suggest that disruption has generally been limited. In most countries, new entrants tend to be integrated and assimilated into existing systems, while incumbent banks' intermediary positions have proven hard to dislodge (Kremers and Brassett, 2017). Fintechs have only affected the front end of banking, which 'leaves the role of major banks untouched' as Fintech innovations are integrated into existing payments systems rather than disrupting them (Brandl and Dieterich, 2023: 551; Chiu, 2017). Furthermore, although disruption has been used as a tactic to force governance and regulatory change

in industries such as taxis and hotels, the tight regulation of banking and political prioritisation of financial stability tends to limit these strategies. Conversely, some states have seen disruption and its potential spillover across borders as serving their international interests. Regulators worldwide have been wary of Fintech's dangers to financial stability, though in cases such as Germany and the UK, governments took a tolerant approach out of a desire to compete in the global financial industry (Hodson, 2021). There has also been discussion of how payments technologies could help China internationalise its currency and disrupt international monetary orders (Chorzempa, 2021).

2 The rise of fintech in China's domestic payments system

China is an outlier in its high extent of payments disruption by digital services firms. One explanation is that pent-up demand due to tight regulation of the formal banking sector in China left a large number of consumers and businesses not served by the formal banking sector (Hsu and Li, 2020), favouring a rush towards Fintech platforms when this financial repression was relaxed (Chorzempa and Huang, 2022: 277–278). Digital services firms starting payments systems were thus initially left unregulated or given policy support by parts of the state, as it was seen to promote economic growth and also unclear which state agency was responsible (Hua and Huang, 2021). Furthermore, 'the higher a country's per capita income and the less competitive its banking system, the larger total fintech credit activity' (BIS, 2019: 60). This suggests Alibaba and Tencent disrupted China's financial infrastructure to an extent not possible elsewhere because it was relatively much weaker when they entered it (Chorzempa, 2022).

Our analysis draws upon this argument but also points to the important role of sub-national state actors in facilitating this disruption, how disruption by digital services firms was deflected or harnessed towards policy goals, and political manoeuvres over intermediation and the informational power derived from it. This section begins by highlighting how China's initial Fintech growth was supported by central and sub-national governments at key junctures. It then examines the interaction between regulation and disruption as Fintech firms competitively innovated and took advantage of grey areas, while regulators sought to strategically harness Fintech, deflecting disruption towards their economic governance objectives. We then examine how, once Fintechs became established, their growing informational power and potential for political disruption became problematic for policymakers, who then imposed tougher regulatory scrutiny and control.

China's digital services firms can be examined through the lens of interactions between capital and the state. Financial and digital technology sectors in China have seen a 'regulatory pendulum' with periods of loosening and tightening (Zhang and Chen, 2022: 1469). Although China stands out for the extent of disruption it has seen in its payments and banking system, this has been harnessed by the state towards its own 'overall legitimacy and ruling capacity' (Gruin and Knaack, 2020: 372).This is in line with the overall strategic worldview of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP)

emphasising innovation-driven development as an element of national security. (Cheung, 2022). While the conventional wisdom about China's 'state capitalism' presumes the dominance of the political leadership and its priorities, since the 2010s this has arguably become more of an 'ecosystem' with dense and complex networks through which authorities and the ruling party 'connect and coordinate' both the state-owned and private sector (Blanchette, 2021: 4; Li, 2016). While the state has asymmetric power in this relationship, the private sector can influence technology policy amid the CCP's internal debates and changing narratives about national interests (To, 2023). The limited and underdeveloped payments and banking system in China meant that Alipay's development, primarily intended to augment its e-commerce business, aligned with CCP governance objectives by ultimately expanding consumer banking and credit to large numbers of Chinese citizens for the first time.

Alibaba and Tencent's payments disruption came as a side effect of innovations meant to support their core e-commerce and platform services businesses. For instance, Alibaba launched Alipay in 2004 as an escrow service, primarily to serve its Taobao online shopping platform, not because it planned to disrupt the payments and banking system (Zhang and Williamson, 2021). Moreover, this infrastructural link to Alibaba's core retail business was the basis for Alipay's adoption and growth, adding new options through partnerships with banking and payments incumbents such as UnionPay and China's state-owned banks. In a similar way, WeChat Pay took off by enabling users to send small amounts of money to each other through its messaging system. It further built up this payments service by offering users a discount for booking taxis through the Didi app, as competition with Alibaba's Kuaidi app heated up in early 2014 (Chen, 2022: 124–125). Alibaba and Tencent aggressively acquired other digital services companies in order to integrate them into competing walled gardens. As a digital services duopoly developed in China, the two firms engaged in aggressive discounting and price competition in the realms of online shopping, taxis, food delivery, and other everyday items of consumer spending. The primary goal was not to promote their payment apps but to seize market share for the company as a whole. However, with offers and discounts through Alipay or WeChat Pay being central instruments of the competition, the payment apps also grew rapidly, and they were able to gain intermediary positions and informational power as a result.

2.1 Disruption with local government support

The rise of technology firms such as Alibaba in Hangzhou and Tencent in Shenzhen was also facilitated by the enabling role of local governments and their relations with the central state. In the early phase, Fintech development was dependent on the state-led banking system. Thus, disruption aligned with and helped accelerate the state's ambition of modernising its payment infrastructure. Local authorities and state-owned banks saw these firms as supporting the local economy and compatible with the state's broader economic modernisation and development goals. Thus, local gov-

Table 1: Progression of Ant Group's payments technologies and regulation

	Alipay 1.0 (2003–2005)	**Alipay 2.0 – Gateway Model (2005–2010)**	**Alipay 3.0 – QuickPay (2010 onward)**
Base technology	Manual escrow system; buyer wires money to Alipay's bank account; Excel spreadsheets for record-keeping; settlements done manually.	Gateway redirection: buyers redirected to banks' online portals; payments required bank-issued security tokens	API integration with banks; users link debit/credit cards directly; authentication streamlined; instant settlement within Alipay's interface.
Informational disruption	Minimal: Alipay only had transaction records as intermediary; banks retained full control over infrastructure and customer data.	Moderate: gained visibility into transaction flows, but banks still handled authentication and settlement.	High: Alipay controlled user interface, transaction experience, and data; banks relegated to back-end clearing; Alipay became primary data holder.
Interaction with regulators	Operated in legal grey zone; supported by local authorities and banks; no direct regulation.	Benefited from local–central lobbying; aligned with PBC's push for online banking modernization; still outside formal licensing.	Coincided with PBC's 2010 licensing of third-party payments; legitimised Alipay as a payment provider; regulators began to see risks of 'deposit-taking'.

Source: authors

ernment support and the central state's tacit tolerance created the regulatory space within which Fintech could take root.

Local authorities often align with the interests of local firms in matters of taxation, regional economic development, and even the career advancement of local officials (Chen, 2023). One indicator of this is the remarkably high success rate that Alibaba and Tencent enjoy as litigation defendants in local courts (Chen, 2021). At the national level, these firms contribute to the status of Hangzhou and Shenzhen as economically vital cities whose fiscal contributions and experimental economic models are highly valued by the central government. These cities often served as testing grounds for policy innovation, and were more likely to receive regulatory flexibility or support because of their outsized contributions to national tax revenue and economic growth (Ang, 2020).

Similarly, the tiered central-local structure of China's banking system gave local banking institutions relative independence from the centre. This central-local setup of national payments infrastructure is a longstanding feature of China's current banking system, which was only built in the late 1980s. In 1989, the People's Bank of China (PBC) introduced electronic settlement of inter-bank clearing, establishing a two-tier structure of national and city-level processing centres, furthering the independent role that local banks and governments play (PBC, 1989). The system remained fragmented in practice, leaving gaps in efficiency and consumer access that Fintech would later exploit.

When Alipay was first introduced in 2003, it functioned primarily as an escrow-like payment service intermediated through the existing banking infrastructure. Its ledger-keeping mechanism known as 'Guaranteed Transactions' (担保交易) helped fill the confidence gap left by the absence of an established credit system and card network. Alipay 1.0 operated as a simple escrow channel: buyers wired funds to Alipay's account, which held them until the buyer confirmed receipt of goods, then released payment to the seller. Core banking functions of credit, clearing, and settlement remained with partner banks, with Alipay acting as an information intermediary and institutional guarantor. Far from displacing incumbents, this model expanded their customer base and transaction volumes without adding credit risk, making it attractive rather than threatening to local banks.

However, by assuming trust and settlement assurance functions traditionally concentrated within the formal banking sector, Alipay operated in a legal grey zone. Though welcomed by local bank branches, it was without any regulatory framework governing and protecting its activities. Jack Ma reportedly reassured staff by promising he would take full responsibility and 'go to jail' if legal trouble resulted (Chen, 2022: 60). When PBC issued its first regulatory guidance on electronic payments in October 2005, non-bank payments remained outside its scope. The regulation addressed banking and financial institutions, not third-party platforms. Thus, Alipay was compelled in practice to maintain constructive relationships with banks and regulators. Since only banks could legally execute the underlying payment and settlement functions, they could have withdrawn that cooperation and effectively shut down Alipay's operations. Incumbents could have halted this disruption at any point, but instead saw it as potentially useful and sought to deflect it towards their own objectives.

The 'Alipay 2.0' model, which redirected customers to their banks' online portals, not only familiarised Chinese consumers with online shopping but also greatly accelerated the adoption of banks' own online payment systems. This coincided with the Chinese government's broader campaign to encourage the modernisation of the banking sector through the rollout of online banking services. The Industrial and Commercial Bank of China (ICBC) branch in Hangzhou was the first to sign a cooperation agreement with Alipay, establishing a direct technical linkage between Alipay's platform and ICBC's online portal in 2005 (ICBC, 2006). Together, they co-introduced the 'Gateway Model' (网关模式), which soon became the industry standard. Under this system, customers were redirected from Alipay to their bank's official online portal to complete transactions, thereby eliminating the need for in-person wire transfers at bank branches. In this context, users needed bank accounts to use Alipay, meaning banking system and Fintech growth were linked in China's period of rapid economic expansion and banks were unlikely to see Alipay as a threat. While data on Fintech's initial growth remains limited, Figure 1 shows that Chinese banks experienced high annual customer growth between 2005 and 2011, with a spike in card ownership growth of 32 percent in 2006, consistent with this narrative.

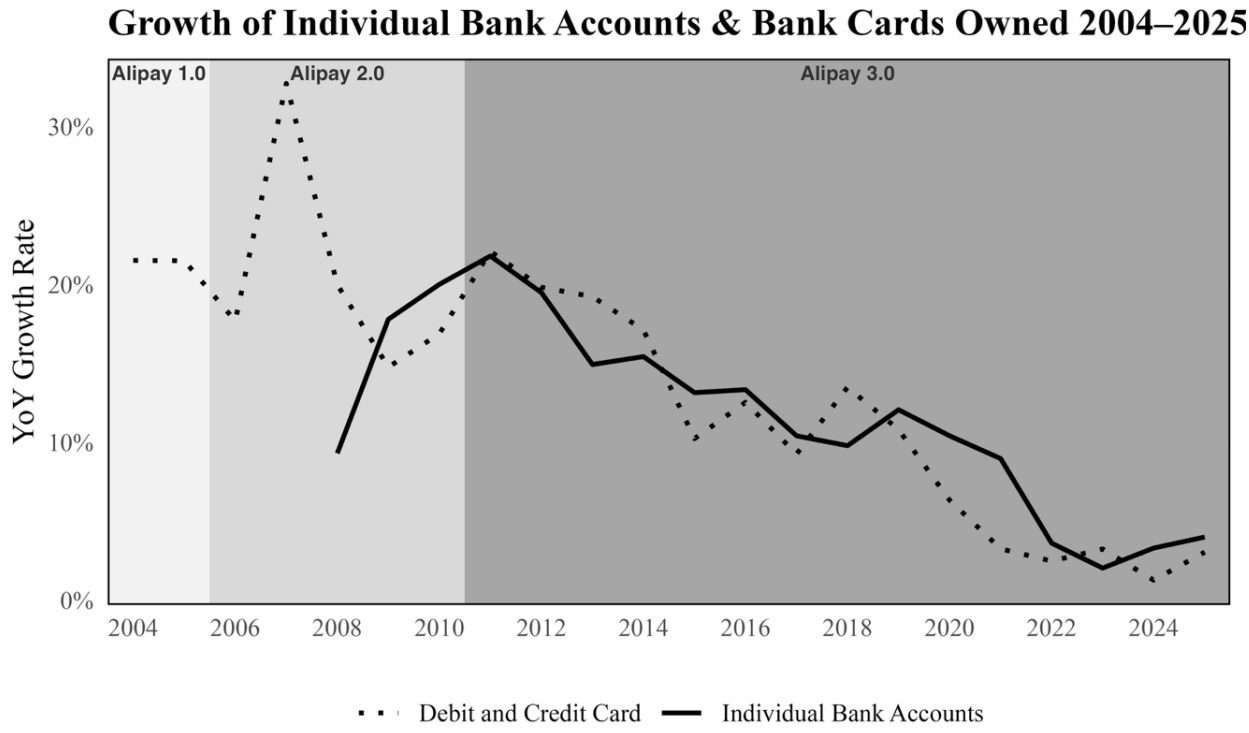


Figure 1: Growth rate of banking services in China over time. Source: PBC Annual Payment Report (2003-2025)

2.2 Intermediation and the dynamics of informational power

The disruptive potential of Fintech intensified as the technology matured and market expanded, particularly as platforms exploited transaction data derived from payment processing. The development of digital payment networks is better understood as a process of reintermediation rather than disintermediation (French and Leyshon, 2004). In the Chinese case, this took two forms: efficiency reintermediation, whereby platforms replicated bank functions at lower cost and greater scale; and brokerage reintermediation, whereby Fintech firms inserted themselves into transaction flows, aggregating consumer behavioural data that had previously been fragmented across disconnected institutions and largely inaccessible to any single actor. Alipay and Taobao's integration of payments with e-commerce simultaneously drove this sector's rapid growth in China and created a consolidated record of consumer behaviour at a scale and granularity that neither the state nor the banking sector had previously possessed. Authorities subsequently sought to harness this capacity, deflecting disruption towards their own governance objectives, while remaining unable to fully control its trajectory as Alipay evolved into an integrated payment platform. This progressive reintermediation ultimately made state supervision more difficult and banking less profitable, because the information underpinning the new financial ecosystem resided with private platforms rather than within the formal banking sector.

During the Alipay 1.0 and 2.0 era, payment flows were channelled through existing state payment infrastructures, while the platform's efficiency and business model steadily attracted a growing customer base. This model facilitated transactions without replacing or threatening critical banking functions. Rather, it strengthened the banking system by directing more customers to online banking, encouraging account usage at state-owned commercial banks, and increasing deposits. In 2007, ICBC's online banking transactions totalled 89.9 trillion yuan, representing a 136 percent increase year-on-year (ICBC, 2008). However, this redirection arrangement introduced friction into the payment process: customers were required to sign online payment agreements with their banks, obtain a security device (U 盾), and navigate repeated redirects between Alipay and bank portals. Transaction success rates reportedly hovered around 60 percent, raising costs and risking the loss of customers (Ren, 2013). While Alipay had streamlined access to the banking system but remained dependent on its infrastructure and subject to its efficiency constraints.

To address these challenges, a major shift occurred around 2010, when Chinese commercial banks began opening application programming interfaces (APIs) which allowed direct interoperability between banks and the third-party payment platforms. Alipay seized this opportunity by launching QuickPay (快捷支付), Alipay 3.0. QuickPay introduced a small-value debit clearing system that allowed users to link their debit or credit cards directly to Alipay, eliminating repeated redirects and streamlining authentication. After a one-time verification, customers could complete purchases entirely within the Alipay interface and leave it to deal with banks for aggregated settlements. Funds were debited automatically from the linked account and settled in seconds, dramatically improving speed and convenience.

This innovation marked a turning point in how consumers interacted with both Alipay and their banks. While banks continued to provide the underlying accounts and settlement networks, Alipay gained control of the user interface, transaction data, and brand loyalty. Instead of logging into multiple banking systems, consumers now entered the digital economy primarily through Alipay, leaving their payment behaviour visible to Alipay while banks were pushed into the background. This reduced banks' visibility and elevated Alipay to the role of a front-end payment network, laying the foundation for later product developments. In this sense, Alipay 3.0 exemplifies the tension at the heart of reintermediation. Streamlining payment flows was technologically rational, but it simultaneously altered the infrastructure in a way that redistributed informational power away from state-owned banks and towards private platforms, an outcome that was politically consequential.

The transaction data accumulated through the payment process facilitated a deeper form of brokerage reintermediation. With the accumulated behavioural data and pooled customer deposits, Alipay possessed the informational and financial resources to move beyond payment processing into credit scoring, lending, and investment products, functions that had been the exclusive preserve of licensed banking institutions. The informational dimension of digital payments is also observable through the competition between Alipay and Tencent's WeChat Pay, which entered the market

ten years later in 2013, but quickly challenged the dominance of its more established rival. With the rapid growth of smartphones, Tencent was able to leverage its informational advantage from messaging and social media platforms into a powerful competitive advantage in digital payments despite its late start.

On the eve of the Lunar New Year in 2015, WeChat made a bold push into payments by sponsoring China Central Television's Spring Festival Gala (春晚) and launching the 'Red Packet' (红包) feature, a virtual envelope of gift money traditionally exchanged at Lunar New Year celebrations. The campaign encouraged millions to link their bank accounts and generated over 6 billion yuan (about US$1 billion) in transactions in just two days (Xinhua News Agency, 2015). By turning a celebratory cultural practice into a digital social interaction, WeChat transformed payments into a form of social currency, emphasising interpersonal exchanges rather than commercial transactions. The event is often described as WeChat Pay's 'Pearl Harbor', a surprise attack against Alipay's dominance setting off a struggle for supremacy in digital payments (Chen, 2022: 63). It expanded WeChat Pay's user base dramatically by leveraging its data on the convergence between social and economic behaviour, which gave it a source of informational power less available to Alipay. The expansion of Chinese Fintechs into consumer credit by leveraging this informational power took the disruption from payments into the financial system. This drew increasing scrutiny from regulators as Fintechs in effect moved into deposit-taking and credit-issuing functions, which had the potential to disrupt the underlying financial architecture and incumbent banks' intermediation roles within it.

2.3 Regulatory responses and deflection

China's Fintech regulatory evolution unfolded in three distinct waves, as authorities aimed to institutionalise and discipline these emerging technologies by incorporating them into established regulatory structures. However, such efforts often proved partial: once technology firms adapted to the new framework, they advanced in directions that regulators had not anticipated, moving beyond the assumptions of the regulatory design. Thus, each regulatory cycle inadvertently opened space for broader disruptive technology and business model innovations, generating new tests of the state's supervisory capacity.

In 2010, as third-party and mobile payments grew rapidly, the state recognised the need to formalise and supervise this new sector through a direct licensing regime rather than the initial indirect supervision through banks. Many emerging payment firms welcomed regulatory clarity, which reduced uncertainty and legitimised their operations. This recognition culminated in the Administrative Measures for the Payment Services of Non-Financial Institutions (非金融机构支付服务管理办法). Importantly, the measures only allowed Fintechs to offer payment services and prohibited deposit-taking and credit-issuing.

However, as the payment efficiency increased and the practice of redirecting to bank portals stopped, customers found it convenient to leave balances in their Alipay accounts, effectively turning Alipay into a deposit taker. This development alerted regulators, as payment platforms began encroaching on functions that had historically been monopolised by the formal banking sector. In response, the PBC introduced the Administrative Measures for the Custody of Customer Reserve Funds of Payment Institutions (支付机构客户备付金存管办法) in 2013. The regulation required payment institutions to deposit 100 percent of customer reserve funds – the remaining balance in users' virtual wallets – into designated custodial accounts at commercial banks, prohibiting payment firms from using this float for lending or investment.

However, this restriction spurred another innovation. Unable to directly use reserve funds, Alipay created a workaround by channelling idle balances into regulated financial products. Instead of Alipay itself deploying customer funds, Yu'e Bao provided users with a gateway into licenced investment vehicles that complied with regulatory requirements. Leveraging its direct access to consumers and highly efficient transaction processing capabilities, this effectively disintermediated the legacy banking sector by providing consumers with easily accessible channels to financial products that were previously difficult to acquire. This blurring of the line between payments and investment helped Yu'e Bao grow rapidly to become the world's largest money market fund. This illustrates how authorities' responses to banking industry disruption ended up deflecting it unintentionally towards consumer investment. Despite strong opposition from traditional banks, the government did not immediately impose harsh measures to suppress the product. Instead, regulators allowed Alibaba to expand further into financial services by granting its affiliate, Ant Financial, a banking licence to establish MYbank (Zhejiang E-Commerce Bank) in 2015. This allowed the group to engage in credit and investment activities through a regulated banking entity.

At the same time, a third wave of Fintech regulation was beginning to take shape, in effect an effort by authorities to harness Fintechs' payments intermediation and informational advantages. Between 2015 and 2017, regulators moved to reassert control over clearing and settlement infrastructure. In January 2017, the PBC required third-party payment providers to move 20 percent of customer reserve funds into non-interest bearing accounts with the central bank (PBC, 2017). As traditional banks were required to deposit 18 percent of such funds, this created a significant disadvantage for Fintechs, particularly smaller providers reliant on interest from using the float for institutional short-term lending (Zhang and Shen, 2019). In May 2017, regulators went further by establishing the NetsUnion Clearing Corporation, under PBC's direct supervision and built on the state-owned UnionPay network. NetsUnion was designed to centralise clearing for all online payment transactions, requiring that all information and fund transfers between third-party payment institutions and banks be routed through the new platform. By enfolding Fintechs' data-gathering into systems of algorithmic governance and social engineering, this helped authorities maintain informational power which could have been disrupted by disintermediation of banks (Gruin, 2019: 224–228).

This tightening scrutiny was the context for Jack Ma's controversial speech at the Bund Summit in Shanghai in October 2020. While commonly seen as triggering a crackdown on Fintech, the speech may be better seen as a last-ditch effort to stall it (see also Chorzempa, 2022: 215–220). Ma might also have overestimated the extent to which state authorities shared his ambitious goals for China's Fintech sector and regarded him as a systemic stakeholder, rather than mere policy follower whose disruption was only tolerated if compatible with authorities' goals. In either case, Ma's emphasis on how the disruptive potential of Fintech for regulatory frameworks is rooted in the informational power that technology enables would have confirmed leaders' concerns about how Fintech might reallocate informational power away from the state and foster political disruption (Ma, 2020). Shortly thereafter, Xi Jinping personally ordered the suspension of Ant Group's long-anticipated initial public offering (IPO), which had been in preparation for months and was expected to be the largest in history (Yang and Wei, 2020).

Against this backdrop of tightening regulatory limitations at home, with competition shifting away from disruptive breakthroughs toward incremental improvements, leading Chinese Fintech firms have increasingly sought opportunities to expand internationally. Ant Group and Tencent, in particular, have pursued global strategies by investing in overseas payment platforms, forming partnerships with local financial institutions, and promoting cross-border payment services. Notable examples include Ant's investment in Paytm in India, Kakao Pay in South Korea, and Ascend Money in Thailand, as well as WeChat Pay's expansion into Hong Kong and across Southeast Asia. These initiatives illustrate how Chinese Fintech has sought to leverage its domestic experience and technological infrastructure to position itself as a key player in the emerging architecture of global digital finance.

3 Deflecting disruption internationally

Regulatory tightening at home implicitly encouraged Chinese Fintechs to seek opportunities in an attractive neighbouring market, in this sense deflecting disruptive potential abroad. Southeast Asia would seem a favourable region for Chinese Fintech success, as a key destination for China's development aid, infrastructure investment, and loans (Breslin and Nesadurai, 2023; Lim et al., 2022). Indeed, some argue that Chinese Fintechs represent a new wave of firms embarking on a 'going out' strategy (Han, 2021; He, 2024). Retailers in Southeast Asian countries commonly cater to Chinese tourists by accepting Alipay and WeChat Pay; China is the largest non-ASEAN origin of tourists in the region with 10.5 million visitors accounting for 10.4 per cent of total visits in 2023 (ASEAN, 2024: 66). Ant Group's international operations are headquartered in Singapore, indicating the importance of the region to its international ambitions. However, the potential disruption of international monetary orders in Southeast Asia by Chinese Fintechs has been deflected strongly by regional actors. Although generally welcoming economic investment and links with China, as

with retailers catering to tourists by accepting Alipay, governments in Southeast Asia had few incentives for a permissive approach towards Chinese Fintechs as there were already thriving and competitive digital platforms within the region.

Chinese Fintechs have not gained large proportions of users, supplanted regional competitors, or reintermediated payments and financial infrastructures. We begin this section by examining the developed digital services and Fintech environment that already existed in many Southeast Asian countries. This resulted from their active and continuing efforts to build payments infrastructures that foster competition and interoperability. Finally, we consider the potential for Fintech innovation to disrupt cross-border payments and trade finance, emphasising the agency that Southeast Asian states can individually and collectively exert amid disruption of the regional currency order.

One reason Chinese Fintechs have not had similar disruptive impacts internationally is that major Southeast Asian economies already had formidable digital services platforms of their own. Furthermore, key to Alipay and WeChat Pay's success was their integration into wider platforms offering services for consumers to buy through the payment systems, while augmenting their informational power. In contrast, they struggled to gain traction in Southeast Asia where they entered digital markets that were already developed and competitive (Athique, 2019), were unable to gain a large proportion of users, and thus could not leverage data about their behaviour and transactions into disruptive informational power. In 2024, WeChat Pay pulled out of Malaysia, failing to compete effectively despite the advantage of a pre-existing user base for its messaging app among Malaysians of Chinese ancestry. Grab, the largest Southeast Asian digital services platform, does not even list the Chinese firms as its main digital payments competitors in its annual report; it identifies Shopee, Google Pay and one-country services such as Touch 'n Go, which has 92 per cent market share in Malaysia, as its rivals instead (Grab, 2025: 12; Statista, 2025). Indeed, Grab had already seen off a challenge from Uber, which pulled out of the market and sold its Southeast Asian business to Grab in 2018.

The integration of payments, credit and financial services Ant and Tencent pursued in China is less feasible in Southeast Asia due to strong regulation and highly competitive incumbents, which contrasts with the favourable and facilitative treatment they enjoyed from local authorities and banking incumbents in China. Retail payments systems are thus not a likely avenue for China's Fintechs to disrupt Southeast Asia's monetary order. In 2019, Singapore specifically banned payment platforms from offering credit other than through licenced financial institutions, closing off this avenue of financial disruption. A cabinet minister explicitly cited preventing disintermediation of existing banks and the interests of financial stability as motives for the legislation (Parliament of Singapore, 2019). Indonesia's regulations similarly force firms to choose between offering consumer or 'back-end' business payment services, and require payment providers to be majority-owned and controlled by Indonesian citizens. Credit and debit card systems predominate in Southeast Asia's major economies, and use of mobile payments has plateaued in countries such as Indonesia, Singa-

pore, and Thailand (Yeo, 2025).

China's Fintechs do play a larger role in the region's less-developed countries, which have proportionally greater volumes of borrowing and investment flows with China. Cambodia and Laos stand out in this regard. However, even here foreign payment apps do not enjoy free rein. Cambodia's central bank successfully introduced the Bakong digital payments system in 2020, using technology supplied by Japanese company Soramitsu, and Laos engaged the same company and began a trial of its own system in 2023. This highlights how even relatively small economies are able to harness and deflect Fintech disruption in ways that keep reintermediation inside their territories, while maintaining a diversity of external partners.

Hence, Chinese platforms in Southeast Asia have thus been limited to acquisitions, investments, and joint ventures in existing businesses. Ant Group acquired online marketplace Lazada in 2018, while ByteDance acquired a majority stake in Tokopedia, and folded the regional operations of TikTok Shop into it as Tokopedia is the better-known brand in Southeast Asia. However, equity stakes do not necessarily or simply translate into political influence or governmental 'reach' (Rabe and Kostka, 2023). These investments instead suggest that the Chinese platforms have tacitly accepted their inability to compete in the region, and these stakes are relatively small and do not give Chinese investors decisive influence over executive decisions. Moreover, their influence contends with that of other local and international shareholders. As of March 2025, the majority of Gojek's shares are publicly traded on the Indonesian stock exchange, and Taobao's stake of 7.4 per cent in Gojek is slightly less than that of Softbank, while previous investors included Singapore's state investment fund Temasek, Google, and US-based private equity firms Warburg Pincus and KKR. Grab's growth was propelled by investment not only from China, as with the 2017 investment of US$2 billion from Didi Chuxing (BBC News, 2017), but from Japan-based Softbank and US-based Uber.

Southeast Asian governments are also using Fintech themselves to construct cross-border payment systems and leading their own regional initiatives. Nationally standardised QR codes ensure interoperability between competing digital payment providers and reducing the barrier for users switching between them. While open to foreign providers like the Chinese Fintechs, these systems help prevent any one platform gaining dominance by fostering competition between them, while ensuring any reintermediation remains within the national banking system. Standardised national QR code systems were launched in Malaysia, Singapore, and Thailand in 2018, and were already established by the time Ant Group introduced 'Alipay+' in 2020, a service allowing travellers to use their home country wallets for purchases through an Alipay gateway. At the 2023 ASEAN Summit, member states agreed on an initiative for regionally integrated QR code payments, which is also aimed at increasing use of their own currencies in cross-border payments within the region (ASEAN, 2023). The Project Nexus collaboration between India, Malaysia, the Philippines, and Singapore would also allow individuals to send instant payments between these countries through

mobile phone numbers. These rules shape a highly competitive market for payments, helping to contain and diffuse private informational power. Coalitions and collaborations on wholesale central bank digital currencies, which are in effect experimental payment systems, could also reduce the need for intermediation by private firms in cross-border payments for both consumer and business users. Acting to build their own digital retail and wholesale payments systems is one way that governments in Southeast Asia have harnessed Fintech disruption for their own purposes (cf. Bilotta, 2026; Magurno et al., 2026).

Another policy approach that Southeast Asian governments have used to harness Fintech disruption is to create 'regulatory sandboxes' in which Fintech firms are given exemptions from regulations allowing them to test financial innovations within a controlled environment. This strategy aims at 'experimental learning' by regulators and to improve financial sector competitiveness (Omarova, 2020: 37). Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore, and Thailand are among the countries that have created such schemes. Looking at the rules which have been relaxed within sandboxes and those which are not, it is clear that regulators are willing to tolerate financial risk; indeed, in one view sandboxes demonstrate regulatory deference to Fintech and obscures their excessively risky nature (Brown and Piroska, 2022). However, sandboxes rarely relax rules that aim to prevent misuse of personal data or money laundering. An avenue of disruption authorities are also unwilling to accept is the circumvention of regulations by services based outside their borders. Singapore and Thailand have specific criminal offences for advertising or soliciting customers for payment services not licenced by their governments. While sandboxes signal their willingness to accommodate Fintech disruption that promotes growth and innovation, they harness it with limits on the informational power of platforms and to ensure any reintermediation within the payments infrastructure is retained within the country.

3.1 Trade finance and impacts on regional currency orders

One further possibility is that Fintech could disrupt trade payments and financing. Trade finance is an aspect of cross-border payments that is both complex and lacking in systematic data (Cavoli et al., 2025), but payment methods used are often chosen to address concerns about contract enforcement and institutional quality (Antràs and Foley, 2015). Difficulties with trade finance and payments tend to be greater in countries with low institutional quality, or in transactions that involve small and medium enterprises.

A key concern for trade finance is not only about transferring value, but also managing risk and who bears losses if things go wrong. The commonly-used letter of credit system involves a bank guaranteeing payment to the seller. This allows the exporting seller to delegate risk to the issuing bank, which assumes the problem of pursuing claims against importing buyers in case of default, or conversely deciding when non-payment for late or faulty goods is justified (Antràs and Foley,

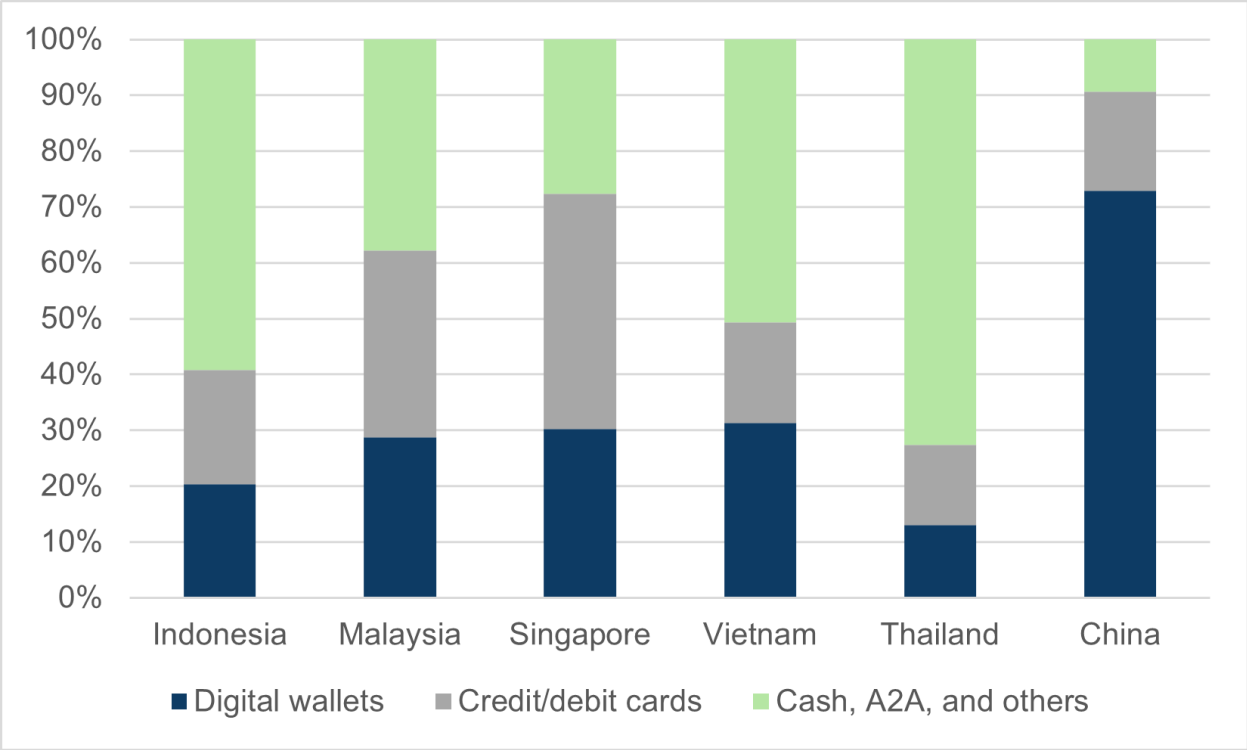


Figure 2: Estimated value of consumer payment transactions and types in China and five largest Southeast Asian economies, 2024. A2A ('account-to-account') refers to payments made directly between bank accounts, such as using Thailand's PromptPay. Author calculations based on Worldpay Global Payments Report (WorldPay, 2025)

2015; Cavoli et al., 2025). Retail payment systems, which include central bank digital currencies, are currently too limited for the large amounts transacted in business-to-business transactions such as international trade, although they address commitment problems between firms that are fundamentally similar to those faced by transacting individuals. The adoption of analogous technological improvements to established systems could reduce transaction costs and creates one possibility of disruption to international monetary orders through choices by firms about which currency to use in international trade. By potentially altering the factors affecting the choice of currency in which to conduct international transactions, technological change in trade financing could affect international currency hierarchy, and thus disrupt international monetary orders (Cohen, 2019; Quaglia and Verdun, 2026). The US dollar's widespread use for trade between Southeast Asian countries reflects and contributes to its position at the top of the global hierarchy, as its high liquidity makes it convenient to use for trade financing and as a vehicle currency. Overall, payments technologies could make it more feasible for Southeast Asian firms to use their home currencies instead. Notably, Japan and eurozone members already conduct most of their trade in yen and euros (Ito and Kawai, 2021).

Fintech firms are not the only agents of change in payment systems that might lead to such disrup-

tion. Indeed, major central banks have already instituted the real-time gross settlement systems that could facilitate this (Jeffs, 2008). China's government has worked to create infrastructure that could facilitate renminbi internationalisation in the back-end of the payments system by establishing offshore clearing banks and a system for cross-border payments, which parallels the Federal Reserve's CHIPS system (Perez-Saiz and Zhang, 2023). In this context, cooperation on international payment settlement between central banks, such as mBridge which includes China and Thailand as participants, could contribute to disrupting the intermediary position of the US dollar (Chu et al., 2025). However, creating this possibility does not mean that disruption will necessarily follow. Such a move would require Southeast Asian businesses to be willing to accept renminbi for their exports, instead of their home currencies or US dollars. This is not a given, since a major obstacle to the currency's international acceptance is that China's capital controls limit the liquidity and convertibility of the renminbi. Moreover, such networks could also reduce the need to use any vehicle currency for trade, and Southeast Asian countries are actively building cross-border payments infrastructure between themselves. Examples include the 2016 launch of the Local Currency Settlement Framework, or attempts to internationalise currencies within the region, as with Thailand's attempt to create a baht zone through its trade with Laos and Myanmar (Ito and Kawai, 2021). Southeast Asian countries hence assert their own currency statecraft, and their interactions with Beijing are part of a broader hedging of their international relationships. This context helps avoid underplaying the agency that states and other actors in Southeast Asia have and seek to maintain as they navigate political tensions in the world economy.

4 Conclusion

The payments system is a basic infrastructure that shapes the economic and social life of a society. China stands out for the drastic extent to which online non-bank providers have transformed its payments system. Nevertheless, the state has been able to deflect domestic Fintech-driven disruption towards its goals while containing challenges to its political and economic control. The development of Fintech in China was not initially perceived as problematically disruptive by the state. Especially at the provincial and municipal levels, authorities maintained a supportive relationship with the platforms. Even as QuickPay and Yu'e Bao marked the first signs of Alipay and other Fintechs encroaching on the traditional functions of the banking sector, regulators did not fundamentally oppose their growth.

During the 2010s, China's Fintechs experienced increasing regulatory scrutiny and intervention, while reaching the limits of China's vast domestic market. Their pace of rapid and disruptive technological change trailed off, and they began to move into 'normal' competition against the established state-owned banks. This was also a period in which they pushed into Southeast Asia, which might have been seen as a region ripe for disruption given their massive scale and implicit state

backing. However, Chinese Fintech's disruptive impact on international monetary orders has been limited because they were entering into markets that were already highly competitive. Furthermore, Southeast Asian regulators similarly sought to harness disruption and ensure sovereign control over their own banking and payments systems. This highlights that governments and regulators have a high degree of agency to deflect and harness the course of Fintech disruption despite the massive economic and political capital that Fintech often marshals (Campbell-Verduyn et al., 2026).

In a broader context, our argument emphasises that technological disruption is not solely driven by innovation and capital, but can be deflected by state actors towards their governance objectives. While this accords with arguments about a symbiotic relationship between states and digital platforms (Rolf and Schindler, 2025), a tendency to focus on China-US rivalry implicitly assumes other states have little agency. Instead, building domestic infrastructures in digital payments while shaping markets towards competition from a diversity of service providers are strategies many states are using to deflect Fintech disruption. Policymakers have noted the importance of intermediation and ensuring it remains within their regulatory grasp. In the international context, reintermediation of cross-border payments could have implications for international monetary orders which are an area for future investigation.

Further research could address the extent to which Southeast Asian policymakers saw China's domestic experience as a warning of Fintech's disruptive potential, or had political concerns about the arrival of China's Fintech firms. A wider scope could also address the limitation that these dynamics may be regionally specific to eastern Asia (Steinberg, 2019). Overall, we see this as indicative that both Fintech's impact and its constraints depend greatly on how authorities respond, and different means towards broadly similar goals of competitive and efficient payment systems that they aim to accomplish through harnessing Fintech. More broadly, we thus point to the disruption of payments and financial infrastructures as being strongly influenced by policy choices and political manoeuvres, not the inevitable result of technological change.

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